Conservation practices

Soon after the island biogeography theory was developed, ecologists began to apply it to conservation. Nature reserves and national parks were seen as “islands” in landscapes altered by human activity. When first creating protected areas, ecologists debated the optimum size: was one big reserve better than several smaller ones? As the island theory shows, biodiversity depends on a number of factors, and different species benefit in different settings. A sizable mammal will not survive in a small reserve, but many small organisms will thrive there. In places under pressure from human activity, the island theory has also encouraged the creation of wildlife corridors. These link areas of suitable habitat, which helps maintain ecological processes—for example, allowing animal movement and enabling viable populations to survive—without requiring a great expansion of protected areas.

“I will argue that every scrap of biological diversity is priceless …”

Edward O. Wilson